



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: First Presbyterian Church School

School Website: <https://fpptacoma.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS STARTUP

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because ACCS require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

First Presbyterian Church School WA 98402 (operating as First Presbyterian Preschool in Tacoma) presents a religiously grounded early childhood program with clear theological orientation, community emphasis, and family partnerships. Public-facing materials emphasize a Christ-centered, Bible-based approach, character formation, and a strong sense of home-school partnership. While the program demonstrates several classical-oriented signals (notably in its religious/metaphysical framing and emphasis on formation and family), it lacks explicit integration of core classical curriculum content (great books, liberal arts disciplines) and certain classical teaching methods (Socratic dialogue, formal rhetoric, and memory-focused pedagogy) that would push it into a fuller classical category. On balance, the school exhibits meaningful classical-oriented traits, but the overall alignment is best described as **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**, with clear room for needle-moving improvements in curriculum content, pedagogy, and explicit articulation of the classical aims to families.

Key insights:

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations are strongly present (God's Word, Bible curriculum, Christ-centered program, character formation).
- Purpose/Goal emphasizes formation, virtue, and a lifelong love of learning in a faith-infused frame.
- Curriculum shows preschool-level Core Classes and Integrated STEAM, but no explicit Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, or Great Conversation elements.
- Pedagogy leans toward hands-on/Project-based approaches, which signals a negative alignment for strict classical pedagogy.
- Faculty signals include long-tenured staff and a sense of mentorship, though not an explicit "living curriculum" portrait.
- Parents & Community emphasis on partnership with families and home-school alignment aligns with classical expectations of parental involvement, though explicit "co-teacher" framing is not fully developed.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

- Evidence
- Public materials emphasize a Christ-centered, Bible-based program and theology-centered formation. Phrases include "grounded in God's Word," "Bible curriculum," and "Christ-centered program."
- The program explicitly frames character-building and moral formation through a faith lens (e.g., "character building," "God created us in His image").
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: God's Word, Bible curriculum, Christ-centered, character building/moral formation, faith, theology. (These map to the Positive Keywords for Element 1 in the Six Essential Elements lexicon, including theology/sacred scripture and moral formation concepts.)
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials.
- Why this rating
- The school foregrounds religious/theological foundations—core to transcendental moral realism and liturgical life in classical theory—while not explicitly stating liturgical practices in a formal sense. The emphasis on theology and sacred text aligns with classic forms of metaphysical grounding, earning a CLASSICAL orientation in this category while still being limited by program scope (preschool level) and lack of explicit liturgical practice in the public-facing material. See the direct religious framing in the FP Preschool materials.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The mission centers on formation and cultivation of virtue and love of learning within a faith context (e.g., “cultivating a lifelong love of learning and a vibrant faith”).
- Emphasis on character building and moral formation parallels the classical aim of forming the soul and intellect toward the true, good, and beautiful within a transcendent frame.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, love of learning, character formation (proxied by “character building”), moral imagination (implied), sacred/Christ-centered orientation (theology-related terms).
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials.
- Why this rating
- The school prioritizes formation and virtue within a theocentric frame, aligning with the classical aim of pursuing truth, goodness, and beauty via formation rather than purely information transfer or job preparation. The public materials strongly signal a transformative educational telos rather than a purely utilitarian one. This supports CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Curriculum details show Core Classes (e.g., Little Miracles, Morning Pre-K, Integrated STEAM) with emphasis on language arts, math, science, art, music, and Bible. There is no explicit mention of the liberal arts framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric) or the Great Books/Great Conversation approach.
- The presence of STEAM and Bible-focused curriculum dominates, with no explicit Great Books, primary source, or Trivium/Quadrivium signaling text.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: none from the classical curriculum lexicon (e.g., Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books, grammar/logic/rhetoric, etc.).
- Negative keywords present: none explicit in the site language, but absence of classical curriculum elements constitutes a lack of positive signals rather than explicit negative signals.
- Why this rating
- For classical aims, the curriculum should foreground the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Great Books/Great Conversation as foundational content. The FP site centers on faith-based formation and early-childhood disciplines (STEAM, Bible, literacy) without the classical content markers. This aligns with NOT CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Pedagogical language emphasizes hands-on, project-based approaches within an Integrated STEAM program. The explicit phrase “hands-on and project-based approach” is present.

- No explicit mention of Socratic seminars, recursive memory work, or the other classical pedagogy signals in public materials; the presence of project-based learning signals a departure from the classical methods listed in the Six Essential Elements.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: minimal (no explicit Socratic, recitation, or scholé markers).
- Negative keywords present: project-based learning, experiential learning, and hands-on approaches (as evidenced by “hands-on and project-based approach”) map to negative signals in the classical pedagogy lexicon.
- Why this rating
- The classical pedagogy lexicon favors contemplative, memory-based, and Socratic forms of instruction rather than project-based regimes. The FP site’s explicit emphasis on hands-on projects signals a NOT CLASSICAL orientation for this category.

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials discuss staff roles (Lead Teacher, Teacher Assistant) and note the longevity/dedication of the teaching team, suggesting a stable, mentor-like culture. While not explicitly described as “living curriculum” or “portrait of a teacher,” there is emphasis on long-tenured staff and the staff as a central part of school life.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: “long-tenured teaching staff,” “dedication,” “teachers as core/authentic partners in formation” (paralleling the classical notion of teachers as mentors and living curriculum, even if not stated in exact phrasing). The lexicon’s faculty signals (model teachers, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher) are partially reflected in the public material (staff longevity and roles).
- Negative keywords present: none clearly evident.
- Why this rating
- There is evidence of a stable faculty with dedicated staff and leadership roles, which supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Element 5. However, the absence of explicit articulation of a formalized “portrait of a teacher” or “living curriculum” reduces it from CLASSICAL to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The program emphasizes partnership with families and views the home–school relationship as central (e.g., “We minister as an extension of the family,” “home and preschool can work side by side,” and “the home and preschool can work side by side for the benefit of the child”). Public materials also highlight family/community engagement as a core value.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, home–school collaboration, parental engagement, open campus. These align with the Six Essential Elements’ “Parent Partnership” and “Formation of Affections” signals.
- Negative keywords present: none evident.
- Why this rating
- The site strongly supports classical expectations around parental involvement and community formation, meeting the criteria for CLASSICAL in Element 6. The explicit framing of family partnership aligns with the classical emphasis on family formation and shared mission.

Overall Assessment (Aggregate Rating)

- Aggregate classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Rationale: The school demonstrates strong religious/metaphysical grounding and formation-focused aims (Categories 1, 2, and 6) that align with classical education. It shows clear signals of a classical orientation in faculty stability (Element 5) and parental/community partnership (Element 6). However, it does not meet classical curricula standards (Element 3) or canonical classical pedagogy (Element

4) due to the absence of Great Books/Trivium-oriented curriculum and minimal evidence of Socratic pedagogy, with explicit project-based/hands-on approaches dominating in the public materials. Thus, the overall alignment sits between Classical and Not Classical, but the balance tips toward Somewhat Classical.

What Would Move the Needle

- Curriculum (Element 3): Introduce or clearly articulate liberal arts components appropriate to the program level (even if gradually scaled): grammar, logic, and rhetoric concepts adapted for the appropriate age range; exposure to Great Books or sustained encounters with primary sources appropriate for the program level; explicit scaffolding toward “Great Conversation” within a K–12 trajectory.
- Pedagogy (Element 4): Reduce reliance on project-based/experiential approaches as the primary mode of instruction and integrate contemplative, memory-focused, and Socratic-style discussions (where developmentally appropriate). Incorporate memory work, recitation, and structured seminar-style discussions to cultivate disciplined reasoning and rhetorical skills.
- Theology/Liturgy (Element 1 & 6): Increase explicit liturgical and communal practices beyond faith integration, including regular, age-appropriate worship or chapel experiences, sacred music, liturgical rhythms, and family-faith formation activities to strengthen liturgical culture within the school community.
- Faculty (Element 5): Develop an explicit “portrait of a teacher” and “living curriculum” framework for staff, including professional development in classical pedagogy, and publish a clear description of teachers’ roles as mentors and co-learners within a classical formation model.
- Parental Engagement (Element 6): Expand parent formation offerings (book studies, lectures, and parent-teacher workshops) and provide explicit pathways for parents to participate as co-educators, aligned with the classical tradition of household formation and living tradition in the family.
- Public articulation (Across Categories): Publish a clear, school-wide Classical Education Statement that ties mission, curriculum, pedagogy, and community partnerships to the Six Essential Elements and corresponding keyword indicators, enabling transparent assessment and ongoing refinement. The classical lexicon and framework documents can ground this articulation.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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